PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Lexus LX 450

1996–1997 · J80 · FZJ80 · 1FZ-FE

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Head gasket history**
  Look for coolant at the head-to-block joint and ask whether the gasket has been replaced. One Expedition Portal regular calls 1FZ-FEs past 150k miles prone to failure and those past 200k very prone. Others think the worry is overblown. Either way, receipts for a properly done head gasket job add real value.
- [ ] **Knuckle seals**
  Caked grease and oil on the outside of the steering knuckles means the inner axle seals failed a while ago. Slee suggests pulling the square fill plug on the knuckle. If the grease inside is runny, diff oil is getting into the knuckle.
- [ ] **Lockers that work**
  If the truck has the factory lockers, turn them on in low range on a loose surface and make sure they engage. A dead locker is often a seized actuator, which can be rebuilt.
- [ ] **Cooling system and PHH**
  A replaced radiator or deposits in the overflow bottle can point to past overheating, which is bad news for the head gasket. Ask whether the PHH and the bypass hoses under the intake have been replaced. Use Toyota red coolant.
- [ ] **Accident and rust history**
  Slee's checklist covers overspray, filler (check with a magnet), uneven panel gaps and missing VIN stickers. Late 80s had a sticker on every body panel. Get underneath and check the frame for pull marks and rust.
- [ ] **Records over miles**
  Forum regulars put service records ahead of mileage. If the driveline, diffs, birfields and bearings haven't been serviced within 150k miles, one Expedition Portal member says to budget about $2,000.
- [ ] **Hidden wiring**
  Look under the dash below the steering wheel and at extra wires on the battery terminal. A rat's nest of accessory wiring usually means the rest of the work wasn't done properly either.
- [ ] **Drive it**
  Check that the transmission shifts smoothly, the brakes don't pull or pulse, the steering is free of noises from lock to lock, and there's no vibration at highway speed. Blue or white smoke on acceleration means walk away.

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **VIN**
  US trucks start JT6HJ88J. NHTSA's vPIC decoder reads the series as FZJ80L with the 1FZ-FE 4.5 I6, built in Toyota City. The 10th character is the model year (T = 1996, V = 1997).
- [ ] **LX vs Land Cruiser**
  From the outside, only the grille, the side body cladding and the wheels differ from an FZJ80. Inside, look for the LX's leather and extra sound insulation.
- [ ] **Factory lockers**
  Electric front and rear lockers were one of only three factory options. Trucks that have them have locker controls on the dash. Test both in low range on a loose surface.
- [ ] **Center diff lock**
  The center diff locks automatically in low range. US trucks from 1993 lost the high-range switch but kept the wiring, so a plug-in CDL switch can add it back.
- [ ] **Lug nuts**
  From 1995 the 80 Series switched from conical to washer-type lug nuts, so make sure the nuts match the wheels on a truck with aftermarket rims.

NOTES

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